MARATHA QUOTA: A TIMELINE

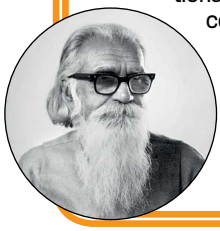
A brief history of the political war over Maratha reservation



1902: Chhatrapati 'Rajarshi' Shahu Maharaj launches affirmative action measures in his princely state of Kolhapur, reserves 50 per cent jobs for those who are not Brahmins, Shenvis (Saraswats), Prabhus and Parsis

1930s: The erstwhile Bombay government declares 228 communities, including the Marathas, as intermediate and backward classes and grants political quotas

1955: Report of the first national backward classes commission led by Gandhian Kakasaheb Kalelkar identifies 2,399 backward communities





Mar. 1982: Annasaheb Patil, legislator and an iconic leader of the Mathadi (head load) workers, organises a protest in Mumbai seeking quota on economic status. When his demands are unmet, he fulfils his suicide threat

1980: The B.P. Mandal Commission submits its report, which estimates 52 per cent of India's population across 3,743 classes as backward and excludes Marathas. It is implemented by the V.P. Singh government a decade later

Apr. 1965: Maharashtra brings 10 per cent quota for backward classes and 4 per cent for de-notified and nomadic tribes in jobs based on the B.D. Deshmukh panel report. This was in addition to the 13 per cent for SCs and 7 per cent for STs

Jun. 2004: Based on Justice S.N. Khatri (retd) commission's report, Maratha-Kunbis and Kunbi-Marathas are added to the OBC category. This is in addition to the Kunbis, already categorised as OBCs

2014: Congress minister Narayan Rane-led committee recommends quotas for the Marathas; later, the Congress-NCP government approves 16 per cent quotas for them and 5 per cent for Muslims. The Bombay HC stays the move

2018: The state backward classes commission led by Justice M.G. Gaikwad (retd) classifies the Marathas as backward. Earlier, three panels had rejected the demand as had the National Commission for Backward Classes in 2000

May 2021: The SC junks the Maratha quota law, calls it unconstitutional. It holds that the Marathas are not socially and educationally backward, and hence not eligible for affirmative action



Nov. 2018: The Devendra Fadnavis government approves 16 per cent quotas for Marathas in jobs and education. The bill is unanimously approved by the state legislature. Later, the Bombay HC upholds the law, but slashes the quotas to 13 per cent and 12 per cent in jobs and education, respectively

government is working on filing a curative petition in the apex court. Shinde said they will work to ensure that the quota was restored and the Marathas secured these benefits without eating into the OBC share. He also said the government will withdraw police cases against the protesters. On September 12, Jarange-Patil said he will continue with his hunger strike till Shinde, Fadnavis and Pawar, and Chhatrapati Udayanraje Bhosale and Chhatrapati Sambhajiraje, the descendants of Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj, met him. The protest will, however, continue for a month.

Maratha leaders claim that Jarange-Patil's demand is realistic as the Marathas and Kunbis are the same. Pravin Gaikwad of the Sambhaji Brigade says that in historical records, the Marathas have been referred to as Kunbis. "There is no caste called the



"THE MARATHAS HOLD POLITICAL POWER. THE POOR FROM THE COMMUNITY CAN GET QUOTAS THROUGH THE EWS CATEGORY"

SHABBIR AHMED ANSARI
Founder-president, All India Muslim OBC Organisation

Marathas.... The ones who stay in Maharashtra are Marathas... caste locations were decided based on occupations. Kunbis were marginal, rain-fed farmers; those among them who took to a martial way of life after completing their farming duties were called Marathas and gradually became generals and noblemen," adds Gaikwad. He notes that it was not possible for the Marathas to get ring-fenced quotas for one caste alone, and hence, they could secure quota benefits either as Kunbis or from the economically weaker section (EWS) category.

On June 1, 2004, the state backward classes commission, under Justice S.N. Khatri (retired), had approved the demand to add Maratha-Kunbis and Kunbi-Marathas to the OBC category. "This means that Marathas and Kunbis are one," he argued. Gaikwad adds that Marathas were gradually getting caste certificates as Kunbis.

The Sir William Wilson Hunter statistical commission in the late 19th century had said that Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj was Kunbi and the Rajas of